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Reflection

This past summer, I worked as a sales associate at Free People, since I was unable to obtain an internship. Although I would have liked to have an internship to gain hands-on experience in the field that I am interested in, working at a retail store provided me with valuable insights into the retail side of a corporation that I respect. On average, my schedule this summer was four days a week for five hours.

As a sales associate, I helped to ensure that our customers' needs are met by delivering high-quality service that results in positive customer feedback. For example, when I am “customer servicing,” I am greeting the customers, assisting them with questions, offering suggestions, asking if they need assistance with putting their clothes in a fitting room, as well as fixing the floor to maintain the “Free People” look that the visual team designed. When I am zoned to be at the cash register, I assist customers' transactions through our POS systems. When a customer does not need help, I will package clothes that need to be transferred out using one of our software programs. This helps to keep the flow of our inventory from our location in Palo Alto, to be transferred to a warehouse in Kentucky. Another part of my job is to fulfill online orders. Through our app, LOF, it shows me the items customers have ordered that we have at our location, so I can “pick” them and then package them up to be shipped. Another big part of the job was to tend to the dressing room area. In this task, I would help a customer into their room by taking their clothes and putting them on the rack, asking them for their name as well as giving

them my name for future assistance. Also, I count the number of clothes that they bring into the fitting room to ensure all of the items are brought back out to prevent theft. The tasks that I was a part of this summer helped to enhance customer service as well as increase revenue.

Before working at Free People, I worked at its sister company, Anthropologie, for a year. They are both under the same parent company, URBN. While I enjoyed my time at Anthropologie, I did not feel as connected with the brand, which was a main reason why I transferred over. Working at Free People has allowed me to expand my customer service skills in a way that allows me to connect better with the customers. Most of my closet was already full of Free People clothes, and wearing the brand to work has helped me relate to the customers as well as drive sales. Customers tend to buy clothes that the sales associates are wearing as it gives them style inspiration and they can see the clothing item in “action” rather than on a hanger. Also, I align with the brand vision more at Free People, which allows me to give better and more creative styling suggestions.

At Anthropologie, I did not partake in some of the online system tasks like LOF or inventory transfer. Learning these new skills took time, but it helped me to see a part of the operations side of the company. I got to understand the flow and logistics of our store's inventory. Also, my knowledge of being a sales associate expanded as I got to understand how to accurately package customers’ orders. Having a more hands-on role has made me have a larger appreciation for the company, as well as feeling like my work has more of an impact, which causes me to have a better work ethic. These skills can help me as I am applying for internships and jobs in the near future.

Although both companies are under URBN, I was surprised at the change in the customer demographic and the additional responsibilities I was assigned to. I had thought that Free People

mainly had a younger audience, but I was wrong. While it caters to a younger audience, customers of all ages are frequent shoppers. What surprised me the most was the customer attitude shift. At Anthropologie, the customers tended to have less patience and a higher expectation for the employees. This caused my attitude at work to become more stressed since I felt like I had to meet their expectations. Their brand image appeals to middle-aged shoppers who value sophistication and quality in their products, since their product lines are elevated and polished. On the other hand, Free People caters to a younger audience that tends to be more laid back and free-spirited. Working with these shoppers has been an adjustment since their style is more casual. My styling suggestions have switched from practicality to creativity. Additionally, I was surprised at the extra tasks that I had. I find the extra tasks to be important since they allow us, sales associates, to learn more about the company and have more of a hands-on role. I think that Anthropologie should incorporate these responsibilities into the sales associates' job roles.

As I reflect on my experience of being a sales associate, I think that I have gained useful skills that put me in a good position for a job interview. Since I want to go into retail marketing, I think having first-hand experience in a retail environment puts me at an advantage. I understand consumer behavior by observing their shopping experience and interacting with their needs. Also, I understand store operations as I work with the visual team to maintain the store displays, strategize marketing decisions, and manage inventory. Working in sales has set me up for success in a job interview because I can express firsthand experiences that have helped me gain the knowledge that I have. Another big part of the job is understanding how to mitigate conflict and resolve issues, which are crucial skills needed for a job, especially in a corporate setting.

I completed my EMPACT analysis on Anthropologie, and while I worked at Free People, both are similar, and some aspects of my EMPACT can be related to both retailers. The

customers have flexible spending habits, which can cause them to shop leisurely and for necessities. Also, if a customer needs an item like jeans, both companies carry a wide range of products that allow for the styles to be catered to customers with different preferences. Also, I have found that if a customer is not satisfied with the selection at Free People, then they tend to go to a sister store, Anthropologie, or Urban Outfitters. While this may be specific to the Bay Area, some customers find the stores to be convenient because there are limited stores throughout the area. This may cause customers to shop at competitors that have more locations close by.

While I would have liked to have an internship this past summer, I gained valuable insights from my work as a sales associate at Free People. This experience has given me meaningful skills that will be useful in my future career, as well as business awareness for a brand that I have admired for a long time. Not only do I value this experience from a career standpoint, but it also helped my personal communication and problem-solving skills.